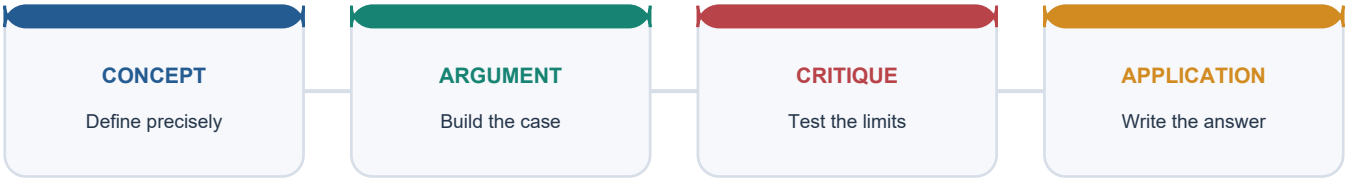
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

The Gupta Empire - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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The Gupta Empire - Solved Practice Workbook

This standalone workbook holds the complete bank: 32 original hard MCQs with strict A-B-C-D rotation repeated eight times, 128 separately identifiable option-level explanations tagged [Qnn-A]-[Qnn-D], and 32 unique examiner traps. Remediation is integrated directly into these 32 items (four per rotation block, at every fourth question) rather than held in a separate duplicate remedial block.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

MCQ 01 - Q1

Which court figure composed the Prayag/Allahabad prashasti of Samudragupta, and what does that authorship imply for its use as evidence?

A. Harishena, a courtier who also held sandhivigrahika and mahadandanayaka rank B. Fa-hien, the Chinese Buddhist pilgrim C. Chakrapalita, the city-governor named at Junagadh D. Kalidasa, the court poet of a later legendary tradition

Answer: A. Harishena's authorship is secure; because he was a serving official, the text is both evidence and courtly ideology, not a neutral chronicle.

- [Q01-A] Harishena's authorship is secure; because he was a serving official, the text is both evidence and courtly ideology, not a neutral chronicle.
- [Q01-B] Faxian travelled decades later, under Chandragupta II, and wrote independent Buddhist-pilgrim observations, not the Samudragupta prashasti.
- [Q01-C] Chakrapalita belongs to Skandagupta's Junagadh record about the Sudarshana lake repair, a different inscription entirely.
- [Q01-D] Kalidasa's court association is a later, debated literary tradition and is never linked with composing this specific inscription.

Examiner trap: Treating every named Gupta text as interchangeable evidence collapses genre and chronology; always match author, inscription and reign precisely.

MCQ 02 - Q2

Chandragupta I's alliance with a Lichchhavi princess was publicised through a distinct coin type. Which princess is named, and what can the coin legitimately prove?

A. Prabhavatigupta; it proves a later regency in the Vakataka kingdom B. Kumaradevi; it proves the alliance was advertised as a source of status, not a measured territorial gain C. Dhruvadevi; it proves a disputed succession story D. Anantadevi; it proves an unrelated Later Gupta marriage

Answer: B. The king-and-queen coin type names Kumaradevi and the Lichchhavis, showing that the marriage was deliberately publicised political communication.

- [Q02-A] Prabhavatigupta was Chandragupta II's daughter and a Vakataka regent two generations later; she has no place on this coin type.
- [Q02-B] The king-and-queen coin type names Kumaradevi and the Lichchhavis, showing that the marriage was deliberately publicised political communication.
- [Q02-C] Dhruvadevi belongs to the debated Ramagupta/Chandragupta II succession tradition, not to Chandragupta I's reign.
- [Q02-D] Anantadevi belongs to a much later Gupta-branch context and is unconnected to this coin type.

Examiner trap: A marriage coin proves advertised alliance and status; it never quantifies a dowry, army size or exact border change.

MCQ 03 - Q3

In Samudragupta's prashasti, how are the Dakshinapatha (southern) rulers generally described, and why does this matter for territoriality?

A. They were made hereditary district governors under direct Gupta revenue control B. They were ignored once nominal tribute was paid, with no further political relationship C. They were captured and then released and reinstated, which signals demonstration of power rather than uniform annexation D. They were annexed into new bhuktis administered by Gupta-appointed uparikas

Answer: C. Capture-and-release is the prashasti's own language for the southern campaign; it indicates a demonstration of paramountcy and reinstatement, not permanent provincial annexation.

- [Q03-A] The prashasti records no hereditary district-governor status for southern rulers; this option invents an administrative arrangement the source does not state.
- [Q03-B] Some post-campaign relationship persisted (reinstatement itself implies continued recognition), so 'ignored entirely' misstates the evidence.
- [Q03-C] Capture-and-release is the prashasti's own language for the southern campaign; it indicates a demonstration of paramountcy and reinstatement, not permanent provincial annexation.
- [Q03-D] No bhukti/uparika administrative structure is attested for the Dakshinapatha rulers in this campaign; that would overstate direct control.

Examiner trap: Southern 'conquest' language must not be converted into a uniform annexed-province map; the source itself specifies release and reinstatement.

MCQ 04 - Q4

A student shades the entire area south of the Vindhyas in the same solid colour as the Gupta Ganga core on an exam map, captioned 'Samudragupta's empire'. Which correction is required?

A. No correction is needed because Samudragupta's campaigns reached that far B. The shading should instead show Huna-controlled territory C. The shading should be removed entirely because no southern campaign occurred D. The southern zone must be shown as campaign/prestige influence with reinstated rulers, not as a directly administered province in the same colour as the core

Answer: D. The safest map convention marks reinstated/tributary zones with a distinct shading or hatching from the directly administered Ganga core, preserving the source's own graded categories.

- [Q04-A] Reach and direct administration are different claims; using one colour for both is exactly the error the prashasti's own categories warn against.
- [Q04-B] Huna control belongs to fifth-sixth-century north-central India, not to Samudragupta's fourth-century southern campaign; this option confuses two different episodes.
- [Q04-C] A southern campaign is well attested in the prashasti itself; removing it entirely denies real evidence rather than correcting the map's precision.
- [Q04-D] The safest map convention marks reinstated/tributary zones with a distinct shading or hatching from the directly administered Ganga core, preserving the source's own graded categories.

Examiner trap: Remedial target: territorial maps must encode graded sovereignty (core vs tributary/prestige zones), not one flat colour for every named region.

MCQ 05 - Q5

Which pair correctly and completely matches Chandragupta II's western campaign with its numismatic consequence?

A. Defeat of the Western Kshatrapas in Malwa-Gujarat, followed by adaptation of their silver-coin tradition B. Defeat of the Hunas in Magadha, followed by a temporary gold-coin ban C. Founding of the Sudarshana lake, followed by issue of a new copper standard D. Annexation of Sri Lanka, followed by adoption of an island coin design

Answer: A. This is the secure pair: the Shaka/Kshatrapa defeat in the west is directly followed by Gupta adaptation of the regional silver-coin idiom.

- [Q05-A] This is the secure pair: the Shaka/Kshatrapa defeat in the west is directly followed by Gupta adaptation of the regional silver-coin idiom.
- [Q05-B] The Hunas were a fifth-century northern/central pressure, not a fourth-fifth-century Magadha campaign of Chandragupta II, and no gold-coin ban is attested.
- [Q05-C] The Sudarshana lake was repaired, not founded, by Skandagupta's officials over a century after Chandragupta II; it is unrelated to any copper standard.
- [Q05-D] No annexation of Sri Lanka by Chandragupta II is attested; Sri Lankan contact in this period is diplomatic (monastery-building requests), not conquest.

Examiner trap: Do not let one correct fact (a real conquest) drag along an invented consequence; each half of a paired option must be independently verified.

MCQ 06 - Q6

The Udayagiri cave-and-inscription complex associated with Chandragupta II's reign is most usefully read as evidence for:

A. a single exclusive Vaishnava state cult that excluded all rival traditions B. royal-religious ideology expressed through the Varaha imagery, alongside surviving Shaiva and Jaina remains at the same site C. a purely defensive military garrison with no religious content D. a land-revenue settlement office unrelated to kingship

Answer: B. The Varaha rescue-of-the-earth imagery fuses cosmic protection with royal conquest symbolism, while the site's plural remains show accommodation rather than exclusivity - this is the historically supported reading.

- [Q06-A] Udayagiri's own remains include Shaiva and Jaina material alongside the dominant Vaishnava Varaha programme, so 'exclusive' overstates the evidence.
- [Q06-B] The Varaha rescue-of-the-earth imagery fuses cosmic protection with royal conquest symbolism, while the site's plural remains show accommodation rather than exclusivity - this is the historically supported reading.
- [Q06-C] The complex is a rock-cut sacred and inscriptional landscape, not a garrison; no defensive-military function is attested there.
- [Q06-D] Udayagiri is not a revenue office; its evidence is religious-political, not fiscal-administrative.

Examiner trap: Udayagiri is ideological and plural evidence, not proof of either total tolerance or total religious exclusivity.

MCQ 07 - Q7

Skandagupta's Junagadh inscription is most directly evidence for which administrative episode?

A. Samudragupta's Aryavarta campaign B. Faxian's monastic itinerary C. Repair of the Sudarshana lake breach by Chakrapalita under the governor Parnadatta in 456-57 CE D. Aryabhata's calculation of the length of a year

Answer: C. This is the inscription's own content: Parnadatta's provincial oversight and Chakrapalita's local repair of the lake breach in 456-57 CE.

- [Q07-A] The Aryavarta campaign belongs to Samudragupta's own Prayag prashasti, composed decades earlier, not to Skandagupta's Junagadh record.
- [Q07-B] Faxian's itinerary is an independent, roughly contemporary Buddhist-pilgrim text, unconnected to this specific provincial inscription.
- [Q07-C] This is the inscription's own content: Parnadatta's provincial oversight and Chakrapalita's local repair of the lake breach in 456-57 CE.
- [Q07-D] Aryabhata's astronomical work (499 CE) is a separate, later scientific text with no connection to this provincial repair record.

Examiner trap: A named provincial official's action (Chakrapalita's repair) is strong evidence for delegated responsibility; do not substitute a more famous but unrelated event.

MCQ 08 - Q8

Harishena is recorded holding sandhivigrahika and mahadandanayaka rank in addition to composing the Prayag prashasti. Which conclusion about Gupta offices does this MOST safely support?

A. That every Gupta officer held exactly one fixed, non-overlapping title B. That poets were legally barred from holding any administrative rank C. That Harishena's titles prove a modern separation-of-powers bureaucracy D. That high Gupta offices could overlap in a single career, so a rigid one-title-one-department model is unsafe

Answer: D. Because one individual combined literary composition with senior military/diplomatic and judicial-sounding rank, Gupta high offices evidently overlapped rather than sitting in separate fixed departments.

- [Q08-A] Harishena's own multiple titles directly contradict a strict one-officer-one-title model; this option asserts the opposite of what the evidence shows.
- [Q08-B] Harishena himself is the counter-example: a court poet who also held senior administrative/military rank, so no such bar existed.
- [Q08-C] Overlapping, personally combined offices are the opposite of a modern formally separated bureaucracy; this option overstates institutional modernity.
- [Q08-D] Because one individual combined literary composition with senior military/diplomatic and judicial-sounding rank, Gupta high offices evidently overlapped rather than sitting in separate fixed departments.

Examiner trap: Remedial target: a single named official's overlapping titles is strong evidence against assuming rigid, department-like Gupta offices.

MCQ 09 - Q9

A Gupta 'vishaya', as attested chiefly in Bengal records such as Damodarpur, is best translated administratively as a:

A. district, headed by a vishayapati and reporting within provincial (bhukti/desha) authority B. village C. province equal in rank to a bhukti D. guild association of merchants

Answer: A. Vishaya denotes the district level, administered by a vishayapati, sitting below the province (bhukti/desha) in the Damodarpur-type hierarchy.

- [Q09-A] Vishaya denotes the district level, administered by a vishayapati, sitting below the province (bhukti/desha) in the Damodarpur-type hierarchy.
- [Q09-B] Village-level units are called grama, with local elders and record-keepers, a smaller unit than the vishaya.
- [Q09-C] Bhukti/desha are the provincial terms; treating vishaya as equal in rank collapses two distinct administrative levels the records keep separate.
- [Q09-D] Guild bodies (shreni/nigama) are commercial associations, not a territorial-administrative unit like the vishaya.

Examiner trap: Do not flatten the province-district-village hierarchy into one undifferentiated word for 'area'; each term has a distinct attested rank.

MCQ 10 - Q10

Kumaramatya in Gupta inscriptions most safely denotes:

A. a fixed modern cabinet minister with an unchanging single portfolio B. a high-ranking officer/courtly rank whose exact duties varied by context and could combine with other titles C. a village-level tax category D. a purely honorary Buddhist monastic title

Answer: B. Inscriptional evidence shows kumaramatya as a high courtly/administrative rank whose precise duties varied by holder and context, sometimes combined with other titles.

- [Q10-A] No fixed, single, unchanging modern-ministerial portfolio is attested; Harishena's own combined titles show duties and rank were not rigidly departmentalised.
- [Q10-B] Inscriptional evidence shows kumaramatya as a high courtly/administrative rank whose precise duties varied by holder and context, sometimes combined with other titles.
- [Q10-C] Kumaramatya is a rank/office term, not a tax category; conflating an office with a revenue term misreads the inscriptions.
- [Q10-D] The term appears in secular administrative contexts (for example alongside sandhivigrahika and mahadandanayaka), not as a Buddhist monastic honorific.

Examiner trap: Translate Gupta rank-titles by their attested variable use, not by assuming a single fixed modern-office equivalent.

MCQ 11 - Q11

The tradition that Kalidasa served at Chandragupta II's court as one of a formal group of 'nine gems' should be handled in an answer as:

A. a securely dated inscriptional fact that anchors Kalidasa's biography B. impossible, since Kalidasa has no connection whatsoever to the Gupta period C. a claim to state only with its chronology flagged: Kalidasa's major classical works are real, but his exact date and the 'navaratna' roster are a later literary tradition, not an inscriptionally verified court list D. proof that Panini served alongside Kalidasa at the same Gupta court

Answer: C. The safe, examiner-grade formulation credits Kalidasa's classical achievement while explicitly flagging that his precise date and the 'nine gems' roster rest on later literary tradition rather than a verified inscription.

- [Q11-A] No inscription securely dates or names Kalidasa at Chandragupta II's court; treating the tradition as an inscriptional fact overstates the evidence.
- [Q11-B] Kalidasa's works are conventionally placed within the broader Gupta-age classical milieu, so denying any connection goes too far in the other direction.
- [Q11-C] The safe, examiner-grade formulation credits Kalidasa's classical achievement while explicitly flagging that his precise date and the 'nine gems' roster rest on later literary tradition rather than a verified inscription.
- [Q11-D] Panini long predates the Gupta period by several centuries and cannot have served at any Gupta court alongside Kalidasa.

Examiner trap: Remedial target: a famous literary association (Kalidasa/navaratnas) must be flagged as later tradition, not asserted as inscriptionally secure biography.

MCQ 12 - Q12

Gupta subordinate rulers who obeyed orders, paid tribute and could later assert growing independence are best described through the phrase:

A. a permanent, unchanging vassal contract identical in every region B. a purely honorary title with zero political content C. direct Gupta district officers indistinguishable from vishayapatis D. a fully developed samanta trajectory of increasing political intermediation, read across the whole period rather than assumed complete from the start

Answer: D. This option correctly frames 'samanta' as a trajectory - increasing intermediation and regional assertion over time - rather than a single completed system present from the outset.

- [Q12-A] The evidence shows growing, not unchanging, independence as central power weakened; a 'permanent unchanging contract' contradicts this trajectory.
- [Q12-B] Tribute, orders and obeisance recorded in the Prayag prashasti show real political content, not an empty honorific.
- [Q12-C] Subordinate rulers are politically distinct from appointed district officers like vishayapatis; conflating the two erases the hierarchy's own distinctions.
- [Q12-D] This option correctly frames 'samanta' as a trajectory - increasing intermediation and regional assertion over time - rather than a single completed system present from the outset.

Examiner trap: Use 'trajectory' and 'intermediation' precisely; do not assume a fully mature later samanta/feudal system existed from the Gupta period's start.

MCQ 13 - Q13

Which land-measure terms appear specifically in eastern Gupta-period records, and what caution applies to them?

A. Kulyavapa and dronavapa, sowing-based land measures whose exact area varied regionally and should not be treated as one fixed all-India acre B. Nishka and karshapana, which are coin denominations, not land measures C. Yojana only, a distance measure with no agrarian application D. Vishti, which denotes labour, not land area

Answer: A. Kulyavapa and dronavapa are the attested eastern sowing-based land measures; their conversion value differed by region and period, so no single fixed acre-equivalent should be assumed.

- [Q13-A] Kulyavapa and dronavapa are the attested eastern sowing-based land measures; their conversion value differed by region and period, so no single fixed acre-equivalent should be assumed.
- [Q13-B] Nishka and karshapana are indeed coin/weight terms, but the question asks specifically about land measures, so this option answers a different question.
- [Q13-C] Yojana measures distance/travel, not sown land area, and is not the term used in the relevant agrarian records.
- [Q13-D] Vishti is a labour obligation recorded alongside taxes, correctly distinguished from land-area measures, but this option does not answer what the eastern land measures actually were.

Examiner trap: Regional technical terms (land measures, coin denominations, distance units) must not be interchanged; each has its own attested domain.

MCQ 14 - Q14

Vishti in Gupta-period grant inscriptions is best distinguished as:

A. a gold coin denomination B. a forced-labour obligation recorded alongside taxes, concentrated in central and western evidence C. a royal ceremonial title D. a Buddhist monastic ordination rite

Answer: B. Vishti appears alongside taxes in several grant inscriptions concentrated in central and western India, functioning as a labour-form obligation or tax.

- [Q14-A] Vishti is not a coin term; conflating a labour obligation with a monetary denomination misreads the grant inscriptions.
- [Q14-B] Vishti appears alongside taxes in several grant inscriptions concentrated in central and western India, functioning as a labour-form obligation or tax.
- [Q14-C] No royal-title use of vishti is attested; it functions as a fiscal/labour category, not an honorific.
- [Q14-D] Vishti has no attested connection to Buddhist ordination; it belongs to the fiscal-administrative vocabulary of land grants.

Examiner trap: Keep vishti distinct from hired labour and slavery; it is specifically a labour-form obligation tied to taxation contexts.

MCQ 15 - Q15

A candidate writes: 'Since land grants existed, the Gupta state must have been a fully developed feudal system by definition.' What is the FIRST corrective step in a sound answer?

A. List every tax term mentioned in the grants B. Assume no trade could have continued once grants began C. Define precisely which mechanism (intermediation, transferred rights, labour obligation, regional chronology) is actually being claimed before applying any 'feudalism' label D. Equate any grant automatically with European-style serfdom

Answer: C. The historiographically sound first step is to specify the exact mechanism, rights transferred, and regional/chronological scope before applying any structural label such as 'feudalism'.

- [Q15-A] Listing tax terms is a later step in an answer, not the necessary first corrective to an unexamined 'feudalism' label.
- [Q15-B] Trade continuation is a separate empirical question (addressed via coinage and route evidence) and does not follow logically from the existence of grants.
- [Q15-C] The historiographically sound first step is to specify the exact mechanism, rights transferred, and regional/chronological scope before applying any structural label such as 'feudalism'.
- [Q15-D] Automatically equating any grant with European serfdom is precisely the unexamined move the question is warning against, not a correction of it.

Examiner trap: Remedial target: never apply a structural label like 'feudalism' before naming the specific mechanism, rights and regional chronology it is meant to describe.

MCQ 16 - Q16

Upinder Singh's assessment of the imperial-Gupta land-grant corpus is best summarised as:

A. secure and extensive, comparable in scale to the Vakataka charters B. entirely fabricated by later dynasties with no genuine Gupta-period grants C. identical in every clause to Mauryan Arthashastra land provisions D. limited: only Skandagupta's Bhitari temple gift is treated as a bona fide imperial-Gupta grant, while the Gaya/Nalanda plates attributed to Samudragupta remain disputed

Answer: D. This is Singh's stated position: Bhitari is the one secure example, while the Samudragupta-attributed Gaya/Nalanda plates remain disputed.

- [Q16-A] Singh's assessment is the opposite: the imperial-Gupta corpus is thin and contested, unlike the comparatively richer Vakataka charter evidence.
- [Q16-B] Some genuine Gupta-period material exists (for example the Bhitari gift); 'entirely fabricated' overstates the scepticism required.
- [Q16-C] The Arthashastra is a Mauryan-era prescriptive text from a different period and polity; it is not a direct source for Gupta grant clauses.
- [Q16-D] This is Singh's stated position: Bhitari is the one secure example, while the Samudragupta-attributed Gaya/Nalanda plates remain disputed.

Examiner trap: Do not silently promote a disputed inscription (Gaya/Nalanda) to the same evidentiary status as a securely attested one (Bhitari).

MCQ 17 - Q17

A non-entry or fiscal-immunity clause found in one Vakataka charter should be applied to a Gupta-period answer only when:

A. the specific charter under discussion actually contains that clause B. it appears in any well-known textbook summary C. a later dynasty is known to have used a similar-sounding clause D. the ruler's title happens to include 'maharajadhiraja'

Answer: A. Grant clauses are document-, region- and date-specific; only the actual charter's own wording licenses citing a particular immunity or non-entry clause.

- [Q17-A] Grant clauses are document-, region- and date-specific; only the actual charter's own wording licenses citing a particular immunity or non-entry clause.
- [Q17-B] Textbook familiarity is not evidence; a clause must be attested in the specific document being discussed, not assumed from general reputation.
- [Q17-C] Later, unrelated dynastic usage does not retroactively prove the clause existed in the specific earlier charter under discussion.
- [Q17-D] A royal title alone says nothing about which fiscal clauses a particular charter contains; titles and clauses are independent variables.

Examiner trap: Grant clauses cannot be generalised from one document to another; always cite the specific charter that actually contains the clause.

MCQ 18 - Q18

Land grants in the Gupta and related-polity period could simultaneously:

A. prove universal urban prosperity and abolish all cultivation B. integrate frontier zones and reward service, while also transferring revenue and building the local authority of intermediaries C. end all state authority in the granted area D. prohibit any future land transaction in the region

Answer: B. This is the historically supported dual reading: grants could integrate territory and reward service while simultaneously strengthening donees and local intermediaries over time.

- [Q18-A] Grants are agrarian instruments; they do not by themselves prove urban prosperity, and 'abolish cultivation' contradicts their frequent purpose of extending cultivation.
- [Q18-B] This is the historically supported dual reading: grants could integrate territory and reward service while simultaneously strengthening donees and local intermediaries over time.
- [Q18-C] Some royal oversight and residual authority typically persisted even in granted areas; 'end all state authority' overstates the transfer.
- [Q18-D] Grant, sale and boundary-demarcation records themselves show continuing land transactions; a blanket prohibition is not attested.

Examiner trap: A single instrument (the land grant) can have two simultaneous, partly opposed effects; do not force a one-sided verdict.

MCQ 19 - Q19

R.S. Sharma's urban-decline thesis for the Gupta and post-Gupta period is best corrected in an examiner-grade answer by:

A. accepting it uncritically as proven for every city in the subcontinent B. rejecting Sharma's evidence entirely as worthless C. comparing site-specific and functional evidence (administrative, sacred, craft, market, port) region by region, since decline, continuity and relocation all occurred at different places and times D. citing only one poetic city description as decisive proof of continuity

Answer: C. The historiographically sound correction reads decline and continuity as site- and function-specific, drawing on both archaeological contraction and literary/institutional continuity evidence.

- [Q19-A] Uncritical acceptance ignores Upinder Singh's counter-evidence of continuing craft production and active sites such as Sanchi, Sarnath, Nalanda and Ajanta.
- [Q19-B] Sharma's contraction evidence (reduced long-distance trade references, fewer merchant/artisan mentions) remains genuine data, so wholesale rejection is equally unsound.
- [Q19-C] The historiographically sound correction reads decline and continuity as site- and function-specific, drawing on both archaeological contraction and literary/institutional continuity evidence.
- [Q19-D] A single poetic description is stylised evidence and cannot alone settle a debate that requires multiple, cross-checked evidence classes.

Examiner trap: Remedial target: the urban-decline debate is resolved by region-and-function-specific comparison, never by accepting or rejecting one historian's thesis wholesale.

MCQ 20 - Q20

Chandragupta II's silver coinage most directly reflects which mechanism?

A. A Huna minting reform imposed on the Guptas B. A total ban on gold currency across the empire C. Roman provincial administrative control of Gupta mints D. Adaptation of the Western Kshatrapa monetary idiom after their defeat in Malwa-Gujarat

Answer: D. This is the attested mechanism: after defeating the Western Kshatrapas, the Guptas adapted the region's existing silver-coin conventions.

- [Q20-A] The Hunas were a later fifth-century military pressure, not a source of Gupta monetary reform under Chandragupta II.
- [Q20-B] Gold coinage continued extensively under Chandragupta II and later rulers; no empire-wide gold ban is attested.
- [Q20-C] No Roman administrative control of Gupta mints is attested; Roman contact is evidenced through separate trade goods, not monetary sovereignty.
- [Q20-D] This is the attested mechanism: after defeating the Western Kshatrapas, the Guptas adapted the region's existing silver-coin conventions.

Examiner trap: Match a monetary change to its specific, attested political cause; do not substitute a more dramatic but unrelated explanation.

MCQ 21 - Q21

Faxian's description of Tamralipti is chiefly useful as evidence for:

A. an eastern maritime node linking India with Sri Lanka, China, Southeast Asia, Persia, Arabia and Byzantium B. a vanished desert settlement with no maritime function C. a Huna military fort D. a Gupta administrative capital located in Gujarat

Answer: A. Faxian's account presents Tamralipti as a continuing eastern maritime node with wide-ranging overseas links, which is its correct historical significance.

- [Q21-A] Faxian's account presents Tamralipti as a continuing eastern maritime node with wide-ranging overseas links, which is its correct historical significance.
- [Q21-B] Tamralipti is described as an active port, not a vanished desert settlement; this option contradicts Faxian's own account.
- [Q21-C] No Huna military function is attested at Tamralipti; it is a commercial-maritime site, not a fortified Huna position.
- [Q21-D] Tamralipti lies in the east (Bengal region), not Gujarat, and functioned as a port, not an administrative capital.

Examiner trap: Named ports and routes (Tamralipti, Bharuch, Sopara) must be geographically and functionally distinguished, not merged into one generic 'trade centre'.

MCQ 22 - Q22

The Gupta-period urban-continuity/decline debate is best resolved methodologically by:

A. assuming uniform collapse across every city B. comparing regional and functional evidence (administrative, sacred, craft, market, port) rather than generalising from one site or genre C. relying on a single coin hoard as decisive D. relying on a single literary quotation as decisive

Answer: B. This is the methodologically sound resolution: different urban functions and sites changed at different times, so region-and-function comparison is required.

- [Q22-A] Uniform collapse is contradicted by continuing activity at sites such as Sanchi, Sarnath, Nalanda, Ajanta and flourishing southern cities.
- [Q22-B] This is the methodologically sound resolution: different urban functions and sites changed at different times, so region-and-function comparison is required.
- [Q22-C] A single coin hoard is one data point and cannot settle a debate that spans regions, functions and centuries.
- [Q22-D] A single literary quotation is stylised, genre-bound evidence and, alone, cannot resolve a debate requiring multiple evidence classes.

Examiner trap: Urban history questions reward comparative, function-aware answers, not a single decisive fact treated as the whole story.

MCQ 23 - Q23

Faxian's account of India during Chandragupta II's reign should be read in an examiner-grade answer as:

A. an empire-wide census with statistically representative data B. a Gupta tax manual C. important but selective pilgrim evidence, shaped by Buddhist purpose, itinerary and translation D. a modern anthropological survey

Answer: C. This is the correct, source-critical reading: valuable but selective evidence, bounded by his Buddhist pilgrim purpose, chosen route and the translation/transmission of his account.

- [Q23-A] Faxian's travel was itinerary- and purpose-bound, not a systematic census; treating it as statistically representative overstates its scope.
- [Q23-B] Faxian's text is a travel/pilgrimage account, not an administrative or fiscal document like a tax manual.
- [Q23-C] This is the correct, source-critical reading: valuable but selective evidence, bounded by his Buddhist pilgrim purpose, chosen route and the translation/transmission of his account.
- [Q23-D] No modern anthropological methodology applies to a fifth-century pilgrim's account; this option is anachronistic.

Examiner trap: Any traveller's account earns marks only when its purpose, route and transmission limits are stated alongside its content.

MCQ 24 - Q24

Which named woman is documented exercising political authority (regency and issuing grants) in the Gupta-Vakataka world, and what should NOT be inferred from her example?

A. Gargi, who is wrongly and anachronistically linked to Chandragupta II's court B. Kumaradevi, who is documented only as a poet, not a ruler C. Vasantasena, a literary courtesan character with no historical regency D. Prabhavatigupta, whose regency and grants are secure evidence, though her example alone cannot prove general gender equality across Gupta society

Answer: D. Prabhavatigupta's regency in the Vakataka kingdom and her own grants are secure named evidence, but her example is an exception that does not by itself establish general gender equality.

- [Q24-A] Gargi belongs to a much earlier Vedic-philosophical tradition and has no attested link to the Gupta court; this option is a chronological error.
- [Q24-B] Kumaradevi is documented through the Chandragupta I-Lichchhavi marriage coin, not as a poet; this option misattributes her role.
- [Q24-C] Vasantasena is a character from Sanskrit literature (the Mrichchhakatika), not a historically attested regent.
- [Q24-D] Prabhavatigupta's regency in the Vakataka kingdom and her own grants are secure named evidence, but her example is an exception that does not by itself establish general gender equality.

Examiner trap: An exceptional individual's documented agency must not be generalised into a claim about the whole society's gender norms.

MCQ 25 - Q25

Faxian's description of Chandalas living outside towns and signalling their approach is significant evidence for which topic, held alongside which caution?

A. Untouchability, held alongside the caution that a pilgrim's selective account is not a full social census B. Gupta naval warfare, with no caution required C. Aryabhata's mathematics, held alongside a caution about decimal place value D. Gupta coinage, with no source caution required

Answer: A. This is the correct pairing: the passage is important evidence for untouchability, but Faxian's selective, purpose-driven account cannot be read as a complete social survey.

- [Q25-A] This is the correct pairing: the passage is important evidence for untouchability, but Faxian's selective, purpose-driven account cannot be read as a complete social survey.
- [Q25-B] The passage concerns social practice, not naval warfare, and every use of Faxian's evidence requires a source-critical caution, so 'no caution required' is doubly wrong.
- [Q25-C] Aryabhata's mathematical-astronomical work is unrelated to this social-observation passage from Faxian.
- [Q25-D] The passage is social evidence, not numismatic evidence, and again the claim of 'no caution required' misstates the rule that traveller evidence always needs qualification.

Examiner trap: Remedial target: even highly specific traveller evidence (the Chandala passage) must carry its source-critical caution every time it is cited.

MCQ 26 - Q26

Aryabhata completed the Aryabhatiya in which year, and what does it centrally explain?

A. 319 CE; the founding of the Gupta era B. 499 CE; the apparent daily motion of the heavens, explained through Earth's rotation, presupposing decimal place value C. 606 CE; the reign of Harsha D. c. 800 CE; a medieval commentary tradition

Answer: B. This is correct: the Aryabhatiya (499 CE) explains apparent daily celestial motion via Earth's rotation and presupposes decimal place value, distinct from the separate history of zero as a numeral.

- [Q26-A] 319 CE marks the conventional start of the Gupta era (linked to Chandragupta I), an entirely different fact from Aryabhata's later scientific text.
- [Q26-B] This is correct: the Aryabhatiya (499 CE) explains apparent daily celestial motion via Earth's rotation and presupposes decimal place value, distinct from the separate history of zero as a numeral.
- [Q26-C] 606 CE marks Harsha's accession, over a century after Aryabhata's text and unrelated to it.
- [Q26-D] c. 800 CE is centuries too late and describes a much later commentarial period, not Aryabhata's own composition date.

Examiner trap: Keep exact dates attached to their exact events; do not let 'ancient Indian science' blur into one undated block.

MCQ 27 - Q27

Which scholar belongs to the sixth century, correctly distinguished from a seventh-century, explicitly post-Gupta successor?

A. Harishena, sixth century, followed by Panini in the seventh B. Kalidasa, sixth century, followed by Aryabhata in the seventh C. Varahamihira, sixth century, followed by Brahmagupta, seventh century and post-Gupta D. Amarasimha, sixth century, followed by Faxian in the seventh

Answer: C. This is the correct sequence: Varahamihira (sixth century) synthesised astronomical traditions, while Brahmagupta (seventh century) is explicitly post-Gupta.

- [Q27-A] Harishena is a fourth-century courtier under Samudragupta, and Panini predates the Gupta period by centuries; neither date fits this option.
- [Q27-B] Kalidasa's precise date is debated but conventionally associated with the Gupta-classical milieu, and Aryabhata's securely dated work (499 CE) precedes, not follows, a 'sixth-century Kalidasa' in this framing.
- [Q27-C] This is the correct sequence: Varahamihira (sixth century) synthesised astronomical traditions, while Brahmagupta (seventh century) is explicitly post-Gupta.
- [Q27-D] Amarasimha belongs to the Gupta classical milieu, and Faxian travelled in the early fifth century, before the sixth-seventh-century figures in this option.

Examiner trap: Chronological-sequencing questions require exact century placement for each named figure, not a plausible-sounding pairing.

MCQ 28 - Q28

Which pairing of a Gupta-period art/architecture example with its patron is WRONGLY matched?

A. Bhitargaon - early brick temple structure B. Deogarh Dashavatara temple - early developed stone temple with an iconographic programme C. Udayagiri Varaha - royal-religious ideology under Chandragupta II's broader reign context D. Ajanta's major fifth-century phase - a direct imperial Gupta court project

Answer: D. This is the wrong pairing: Ajanta's major fifth-century phase is substantially a Vakataka (Harishena of Vakataka) and elite-donor project, not a direct imperial Gupta court commission.

- [Q28-A] Bhitargaon is correctly identified as an early brick temple example; this pairing is accurate.
- [Q28-B] Deogarh's Dashavatara temple is correctly identified as an early stone temple with a developed iconographic programme; this pairing is accurate.
- [Q28-C] Udayagiri's Varaha imagery is correctly linked to royal-religious ideology within Chandragupta II's reign context; this pairing is accurate.
- [Q28-D] This is the wrong pairing: Ajanta's major fifth-century phase is substantially a Vakataka (Harishena of Vakataka) and elite-donor project, not a direct imperial Gupta court commission.

Examiner trap: A shared cultural horizon (Gupta-Vakataka) does not mean shared patronage; always verify who actually commissioned a specific site.

MCQ 29 - Q29

The safest description of the Gupta polity's territorial control, consistent with the prashasti's own categories, is that it was:

A. a strong Ganga-basin core combined with graded, differentiated peripheries (subordination, tribute, prestige diplomacy) B. uniform direct administration with identical intensity everywhere C. a purely symbolic confederacy with no coercive military capacity D. administratively identical to the Mauryan provincial system

Answer: A. This matches the prashasti's own distinctions between annexed core lands, subordinated forest rulers, tributary frontier states and prestige-seeking distant rulers.

- [Q29-A] This matches the prashasti's own distinctions between annexed core lands, subordinated forest rulers, tributary frontier states and prestige-seeking distant rulers.
- [Q29-B] Uniform direct administration is precisely what the prashasti's differentiated categories contradict.
- [Q29-C] Real conquests (for example the Western Kshatrapa defeat) and a functioning core administration show genuine coercive capacity, ruling out a 'purely symbolic' description.
- [Q29-D] Gupta administration is evidenced as less uniformly documented and more delegated than the Mauryan ideal; the two systems are comparable but not identical.

Examiner trap: A high-scoring 'nature of empire' answer always cites the prashasti's own graded categories rather than asserting one flat description.

MCQ 30 - Q30

Which historiographical debate correctly pairs its named proposition with an accurate counter-evidence check?

A. Urban-decline thesis checked only against one Sanskrit poem, with no archaeological cross-check required B. Feudalism thesis (grants, intermediaries, vishti, reduced monetisation) checked against regional diversity, continuing trade/towns and varied grant clauses C. Golden Age thesis checked only by counting gold coins, with no social-distribution evidence required D. Territoriality debate checked only by accepting the prashasti's campaign order as a literal year-by-year chronicle

Answer: B. This is the correctly paired debate and check: the feudalism thesis is tested against regional diversity, continuing commercial activity, and the actual variation in grant clauses.

- [Q30-A] The urban-decline thesis requires cross-checking archaeological, epigraphic and literary evidence together; relying on one poem alone is methodologically insufficient.
- [Q30-B] This is the correctly paired debate and check: the feudalism thesis is tested against regional diversity, continuing commercial activity, and the actual variation in grant clauses.
- [Q30-C] A Golden Age verdict requires checking domain, social group, region and duration together; counting gold coins alone cannot establish universal prosperity.
- [Q30-D] The prashasti is a eulogistic composition, not a literal year-by-year chronicle; treating its campaign order as such misreads the genre.

Examiner trap: Every historiographical debate needs its own specific, named counter-evidence; a generic 'more research is needed' is not sufficient for full marks.

MCQ 31 - Q31

A candidate ends a Gupta Mains answer with the sentence: 'The Guptas were truly great rulers, and so their age was a Golden Age.' Why is this conclusion inadequate, and what should replace it?

A. It is adequate because celebratory conclusions always earn full marks B. It should be replaced by simply repeating the introduction C. It is analytically empty circular praise; it should be replaced by a conclusion that weighs the named evidence and directly answers the directive with a graded, qualified verdict D. It should be replaced by a longer list of ruler names with no analysis

Answer: C. This is the correct remedial standard: a conclusion must weigh the named evidence already presented and answer the specific directive with a graded, qualified verdict.

- [Q31-A] Celebratory, unqualified praise does not constitute analysis and does not reliably earn marks in an evidence-based examination.
- [Q31-B] Repeating the introduction fails to weigh evidence and does not constitute a conclusion at all.
- [Q31-C] This is the correct remedial standard: a conclusion must weigh the named evidence already presented and answer the specific directive with a graded, qualified verdict.
- [Q31-D] A longer name list without analysis compounds the original problem rather than solving it.

Examiner trap: Remedial target: every Gupta answer must end with a directive-specific, evidence-weighted verdict, never with circular celebratory praise.

MCQ 32 - Q32

For a 20-mark Gupta answer, how should named evidence density be scaled, and why?

A. Exactly one example repeated in different words, because repetition shows confidence B. No named sources at all, because broad generalisation is safer C. Only dates, with no named sites, texts or inscriptions D. Five to eight named evidence units plus counterpoint and historiography, because higher marks require proportionally denser, source-diverse substantiation

Answer: D. This is the correct scaling rule used throughout this package: 10 marks needs 2-3 units, 15 marks needs 4-6, and 20 marks needs 5-8 plus counterpoint and historiography.

- [Q32-A] Repeating one example in different words does not increase evidentiary density and is likely to be read as padding rather than substantiation.
- [Q32-B] Avoiding named sources entirely removes the evidentiary backbone that examiners reward at any mark level, especially at 20 marks.
- [Q32-C] Dates alone, without named sites, inscriptions or texts, cannot support the graded, evidence-led analysis a 20-mark answer requires.
- [Q32-D] This is the correct scaling rule used throughout this package: 10 marks needs 2-3 units, 15 marks needs 4-6, and 20 marks needs 5-8 plus counterpoint and historiography.

Examiner trap: Remedial target: evidence density must scale with marks on offer; a 20-mark answer needs proportionally more named, diverse substantiation than a 10-mark answer.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Solved PYQ 1 - UPSC Prelims 2019 Q10 (direct owner: vishti)

With reference to forced labour (*vishti*) in India during the Gupta period, which one of the following statements is correct?

- A. It was considered a source of income for the State, a sort of tax paid by the people.
- B. It was totally absent in the Madhya Pradesh and Kathiawar regions of the Gupta Empire.
- C. The forced labourer was entitled to weekly wages.
- D. The eldest son of the labourer was sent as the forced labourer.

Answer: A. INFERRED FROM AUTHORITATIVE SUBJECT KNOWLEDGE - the official 2019 key is not held locally. Vishti appears with taxes and could operate as labour-form revenue. Evidence from Madhya Pradesh and Kathiawar defeats B; the sources do not establish the wage entitlement or eldest-son rule asserted in C and D. Confidence: high.

Solved PYQ 2 - UPSC Prelims 2020 Q36 (direct owner: scholar-dynasty matching)

With reference to the scholars/litterateurs of ancient India, consider the following statements:

1. Panini is associated with Pushyamitra Shunga.
2. Amarasimha is associated with Harshavardhana.
3. Kalidasa is associated with Chandragupta II.

Which of the statements given above is/are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: C. INFERRED FROM AUTHORITATIVE SUBJECT KNOWLEDGE - the official 2020 key is not held locally. Panini predates Pushyamitra; Amarasimha belongs to the Gupta/Vikramaditya milieu rather than Harsha; the examination convention accepts Kalidasa's association with Chandragupta II, while exact court biography remains debated. Confidence: high for elimination.

Solved PYQ 3 - UPSC Prelims 2025 Q15 (direct owner: Faxian)

Fa-hien (Faxian), the Chinese pilgrim, travelled to India during the reign of

- A. Samudragupta
- B. Chandragupta II
- C. Kumaragupta I
- D. Skandagupta

Answer: B (official Set-A key held locally). Faxian travelled in the early fifth century during Chandragupta II's reign. Samudragupta precedes the visit; Kumaragupta I and Skandagupta are later. His account remains selective pilgrim evidence, not an empire-wide census.

Solved PYQ 4 - UPSC Mains 2022 GS-I Q12 (cross-owner Gupta and Chola culture)

Question / demand: Discuss the main contributions of Gupta period and Chola period to Indian heritage and culture. (15 marks, 250 words)

Solution: Model (15 marks). [CLAIM] The Gupta and Chola periods created two durable but regionally distinct classical repertoires: the former in Sanskritic literature, science, sculpture and formative temples; the latter in monumental Dravida temples, bronzes, inscriptions and temple-centred institutions. [EVIDENCE AND ANALYSIS] 1. Gupta Sanskrit production is represented by Kalidasa and Amarasimha, while Aryabhata's 499 CE Aryabhatiya anchors mathematical-astronomical achievement. 2. Udayagiri, Sarnath/Mathura sculpture, Bhitargaon and Deogarh show Gupta innovation in sacred imagery and structural temple forms. 3. Chola Brihadishvara at Thanjavur demonstrates mature Dravida architecture and imperial inscriptional patronage. 4. Chola Nataraja bronzes join metallurgical skill, bhakti theology and mobile ritual practice. 5. Temple institutions under the Cholas linked land, craft, performance and local society, while Gupta-Vakataka patronage connected courts, temples and monasteries. [LIMIT] Neither period was culturally uniform or socially golden; Ajanta's major fifth-century phase is Vakataka, and Chola achievements must not erase regional patrons or labour. [VERDICT] Together they shaped literary, scientific, visual and institutional traditions, but a high-scoring answer preserves chronology, region and patronage. **Why this earns marks:** It answers the directive directly, uses 5 named evidence units, states what each proves, adds a qualification and closes with a graded judgement.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "PYQ 4. UPSC Mains 2022 GS-I Q12 - cross-owner Gupta and Chola culture", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "PYQ 4. UPSC Mains 2022 GS-I Q12 - cross-owner Gupta and Chola culture", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Solved PYQ 5 - UPSC Prelims 2020 Q82 (adjacent; true owner Topic 19)

With reference to the period of the Gupta dynasty in ancient India, the towns Ghantasala, Kadura and Chaul were well known as

- A. ports handling foreign trade
- B. capitals of powerful kingdoms
- C. places of exquisite stone art and architecture
- D. important Buddhist pilgrimage centres

Answer: A. INFERRED FROM AUTHORITATIVE SUBJECT KNOWLEDGE - the official 2020 key is not held locally. All three were maritime trading nodes. This adjacent continuity question does not establish uniform urban prosperity across the Gupta realm. Confidence: high.

Solved PYQ 6 - UPSC Prelims 2020 Q29 (adjacent; true owner Topic 21)

Kulyavapa and dronavapa denote

- A. measurements of land
- B. coins of different monetary value
- C. classification of urban land
- D. religious rituals

Answer: A. INFERRED FROM AUTHORITATIVE SUBJECT KNOWLEDGE - the official 2020 key is not held locally. The terms denote sowing-based land measures in eastern records; their exact area varied regionally and should not be converted into one fixed all-India acre standard. Confidence: high.

Original solved Mains practice

M1. 10 marks - Examine the evidentiary value and limits of the Prayag prashasti for reconstructing Samudragupta's empire.

Model (10 marks). The Prayag prashasti, composed by Harishena and inscribed on the Allahabad pillar, is indispensable for reconstructing Samudragupta's reign, yet it reconstructs an imperial self-image rather than a neutral territorial survey. Harishena's list of uprooted Aryavarta rulers supports direct incorporation of a northern core, while captured-and-released Dakshinapatha rulers show a different, non-annexationist policy toward the south. Frontier states, ganas and distant rulers who sent gifts or sought alliance reveal a further layer of tributary and prestige diplomacy rather than provincial rule. Read together, these three registers show graded sovereignty rather than one uniform conquest. However, the inscription is a court eulogy: several named places and rulers remain disputed, and its silences cannot be read as an absence of resistance. Used cautiously alongside coins and regional inscriptions, the prashasti supports layered hegemony, not an all-India province map. **Why this earns marks:** It answers the directive directly, uses three named evidence registers, states what each proves, adds a genre-based qualification and closes with a graded judgement.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on "M1. 10 marks - Examine the evidentiary value and limits of the Prayag prashasti for...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "M1. 10 marks - Examine the evidentiary value and limits of the Prayag prashasti for...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

M2. 10 marks - Why should the Gupta age be described as a qualified Golden Age?

Model (10 marks). The label 'Golden Age' is defensible for elite cultural production but not as a description of universal social conditions. Kalidasa and Amarasimha represent a flowering of Sanskrit literature, while Aryabhata's Aryabhatiya of 499 CE anchors a genuine, precisely dated mathematical-astronomical achievement. Visually, Udayagiri's royal-religious sculpture, the brick temple at Bhitargaon and the stone Dashavatara temple at Deogarh mark early, innovative structural and iconographic development. Set against this record, the same age also produced vishti as a labour obligation, continuing untouchability documented in Faxian's account of Chandalas, entrenched patriarchal norms and uneven urban change across regions. A qualified verdict credits the Gupta period as a classical age of high culture and scientific advance in selected domains, while insisting that this achievement was socially selective and unevenly distributed rather than a universal golden condition for every group. **Why this earns marks:** It answers the directive directly, uses three named evidence units on each side of the ledger, states what each proves, adds a distributional qualification and closes with a graded judgement.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "M2. 10 marks - Why should the Gupta age be described as a qualified Golden Age?", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "M2. 10 marks - Why should the Gupta age be described as a qualified Golden Age?", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

M3. 15 marks - Analyse the Gupta administrative system and the role of local notables.

Model (15 marks). Gupta government combined royal appointment and provincial hierarchy with the incorporation of local commercial and scribal elites, producing a system that was real but unevenly documented. At the provincial level, uparikas were appointed by the king and, in turn, appointed district heads; the Damodarpur copper plates from Bengal supply the most detailed surviving record of this arrangement. Below the province, the vishaya or district was headed by a vishayapati, and district boards such as that of Kotivarsha included not only officials but also the nagara-shreshthin (chief merchant/banker), sarthavaha (caravan leader), prathama-kulika (chief artisan) and prathama-kayastha (chief scribe). Skandagupta's Junagadh inscription further shows Parnadatta and Chakrapalita handling provincial and city responsibilities, including repair of the Sudarshana lake breach in 456-57 CE. At the village level, elders and record-keeping actors appear, though no single all-India panchayat template is proven. Harishena's own combination of sandhivigrahika, mahadandanayaka and kumaramatya ranks shows offices overlapping rather than forming rigid departments. Because Bengal's epigraphy is unusually rich, this detail cannot be mechanically generalised to every province. Overall, the system was layered and real, less uniformly centralised than the Mauryan ideal but far from administratively empty. **Why this earns marks:** It answers the directive directly, uses five named evidence units, states what each proves, adds a regional-generalisation qualification and closes with a graded judgement.

Demand decoding: The directive **analyse** requires a direct position on "M3. 15 marks - Analyse the Gupta administrative system and the role of local notables.", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "M3. 15 marks - Analyse the Gupta administrative system and the role of local notables.", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

M4. 15 marks - Discuss land grants as instruments of agrarian expansion and decentralisation.

Model (15 marks). Land grants could simultaneously extend cultivation and integration while transferring revenue and strengthening intermediaries, and their effects must be judged charter by charter rather than assumed. Applications for wasteland, followed by record consultation, payment, survey, boundary demarcation and public notification, show a regulated process capable of extending settled agriculture into new areas. Agrahara and institutional gifts directed resources toward Brahmanas, temples and monasteries, while Vakataka charters preserve exemption and non-entry clauses that illuminate fiscal delegation more richly than the thin imperial-Gupta corpus itself; Upinder Singh identifies Skandagupta's Bhitari temple gift as the one secure imperial example, since the Gaya and Nalanda plates attributed to Samudragupta remain disputed. Subordinate rulers also issued grants, showing that this instrument of governance operated below the imperial level as well as at it, and some charters redirected vishti and other dues toward beneficiaries rather than the crown. Taken together, this evidence supports two simultaneous readings: grants integrated frontier zones, rewarded service and spread Brahmanical and religious institutions, while also reducing direct royal revenue in granted areas and building the local authority of donees and intermediaries over time. Land grants were therefore neither harmless piety nor an automatic feudal transformation; their consequences depended on the specific rights transferred, the scale involved, and the region and period in question. **Why this earns marks:** It answers the directive directly, uses five named evidence units, states what each proves, adds a charter-specificity qualification and closes with a two-sided graded verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on "M4. 15 marks - Discuss land grants as instruments of agrarian expansion and...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "M4. 15 marks - Discuss land grants as instruments of agrarian expansion and...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

M5. 20 marks - Evaluate the nature and causes of Gupta decline.

Model (20 marks). Gupta decline was a prolonged contraction produced by interacting external, fiscal and regional pressures rather than the result of a single Huna invasion. Skandagupta's Bhitari and Junagadh inscriptions present him defending the dynasty and repairing provincial infrastructure, showing that early pressure could be checked rather than immediately fatal. Later Huna power under Toramana and Mihirakula, however, altered the balance of north and central Indian politics more decisively, and coin and inscription evidence for direct Gupta authority thins across western Malwa and Saurashtra after the later fifth century, indicating a real loss of western territory, routes and associated revenue. Succession after Skandagupta is not fully clear, and this uncertainty likely weakened coherent dynastic authority at a critical moment. Subordinate rulers, uparikas and hereditary local officeholders possessed resources and standing that could support growing autonomy once central power weakened, while changes in gold purity, weight and the frequency of low-denomination coin finds suggest fiscal and commercial strain, though these must be checked regionally rather than treated as one uniform collapse. Yashodharman's 532 CE inscription, itself further prashasti rhetoric, marks the assertive rise of a new regional power in Malwa, illustrating how former subordinates and neighbours capitalised on Gupta weakness. Even so, decline must not be mistaken for instantaneous disappearance: regional Gupta branches, cultural production and many local institutions persisted well after the loss of pan-regional paramountcy. The most defensible verdict treats Gupta contraction as a feedback loop in which military cost, territorial and revenue loss, weakened succession and the corresponding rise of regional powers reinforced one another over roughly a century, rather than as a single catastrophic event with one identifiable cause. **Why this earns marks:** It answers the directive directly, uses seven named evidence units across military, fiscal, succession and regional-power strands, states what each proves, adds a regional-uniformity qualification and closes with a graded, multi-causal judgement.

Demand decoding: The directive **evaluate** requires a direct position on "M5. 20 marks - Evaluate the nature and causes of Gupta decline.", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "M5. 20 marks - Evaluate the nature and causes of Gupta decline.", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

M6. 20 marks - Critically examine whether the Gupta state was a centralised empire or a layered hegemony.

Model (20 marks). The Guptas built a genuine empire with a powerful core and widely recognised paramountcy, yet their own evidence describes differentiated control that is better termed layered hegemony than uniform centralisation. Samudragupta's Prayag prashasti itself distinguishes Aryavarta rulers who were uprooted and incorporated into the northern core from atavika forest rulers reduced to subordination, frontier states and ganas that paid tribute and obeyed orders, and southern Dakshinapatha kings who were captured and released rather than annexed. This graded structure is reinforced by direct administrative machinery in the core: bhukti-vishaya provincial and district administration, illustrated by the Damodarpur records, and Skandagupta's Junagadh inscription showing named officials repairing the Sudarshana lake. At the same time, subordinate maharajas retained substantial local authority, could reproduce imperial-style titles, and became visibly more autonomous once central power weakened in the fifth and sixth centuries, which is exactly what a purely centralised model would not predict. Coins and monuments such as Udayagiri projected sovereignty through ritual and ideological means that went well beyond routine tax administration, supplementing rather than replacing coercive capacity. The common comparison with a supposedly fully centralised Mauryan state is itself source-skewed, since the Arthashastra and the edicts are prescriptive or ideological texts and not a complete administrative census either. On balance, Gupta power is best read as a core-centred imperial network: strong and militarily backed at the centre, but organised through graded sovereignty, tributary relationships and delegated authority rather than one uniform administrative colour across the map. **Why this earns marks:** It answers the directive directly, uses seven named evidence units, states what each proves, adds a source-symmetry qualification comparing Gupta and Mauryan evidence, and closes with a graded judgement.

Demand decoding: The directive **critically examine** requires a direct position on "M6. 20 marks - Critically examine whether the Gupta state was a centralised empire or a...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "M6. 20 marks - Critically examine whether the Gupta state was a centralised empire or a...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.